

Lab: What Does Surprise Feel Like?

Objective

Investigate perception as an active, embodied process through reflective journaling that explores prediction, surprise, and sensorimotor coupling through the lens of pattern-feeling without numbers.

Prerequisites

- A quiet, comfortable space for 25 minutes
- Willingness to engage in reflective journaling
- No prior experience required

Part 1: Arriving (5 minutes)

Sit quietly with your journal. Take three slow breaths. Before writing anything, check in with your body. Notice any sensations, feelings, or subtle knowings that are present right now.

Bring your attention to what you are currently perceiving -- sounds, bodily sensations, temperature. Notice: your body already has predictions about all of these. You are not starting from scratch each moment; perception is prediction meeting reality.

Write your response here

(What are you perceiving right now? Which perceptions were already predicted, and which surprised you?)

Part 2: Surprise in the Body (7 minutes)

Through pattern-feeling without numbers, explore prediction error. Close your eyes and reach for an object. Before touching, notice your prediction. At the moment of contact, notice: did reality match? Where in your body do you register the match or mismatch?

Write your response here

(Describe what you predicted versus what you felt. Where did surprise register in your body?)

Part 3: Sensorimotor Exploration (7 minutes)

Explore how movement creates perception. Hold a textured surface still against your fingers -- notice the perception fading. Now move your fingers across it -- perception returns. Through pattern-feeling without numbers, experience how perception and action are inseparable.

Write your response here

(How did movement change your perception? What does this tell you about the relationship between sensing and moving?)

Part 4: Reflection (5 minutes)

Through the lens of pattern-feeling without numbers, reflect on what you discovered about perception.

Write your response here

(How is perception different from what you assumed? What does bodily surprise teach about the nature of experience?)

Reflection Table

Dimension	What I Noticed	Active Inference Connection
Initial awareness		Baseline generative model state
Embodied exploration		Prediction error through direct experience
Pattern-feeling without numbers lens		Course-specific perspective on perception
Integration		Updated understanding through bodily knowing

Discussion

Consider how pattern-feeling without numbers reveals aspects of perception that other perspectives might miss. In Active Inference, every perspective changes the precision weighting of different signals, revealing different dimensions of the same underlying process of free energy minimization.